upon southern Ghur; and another one eastward toward Tiginabad/Old Qandahar, and ultimately back to Ghazna again. Possibly since the time of the Samanids (tenth century), and almost certainly since that of Mahmud Ghaznavi's father Sabuktigin (d. AH 389/999 CE), a series of large residential complexes – and likely a few commercial buildings – had appeared on the Helmand's left bank several kilometers north of Bust, essentially creating an identifiable area *ex urbis*. This exurb's historical name of al-'Askar – now Lashkari Bazar, discussed below – could indicate that, during various moments prior to the eleventh century, the vast plain had been used for military encampments, which were dependent on nearby Bust.[27]

Given the Shansabani presence at Tiginabad/Old Qandahar as of the later 1150s (cf. above and Chapters 1 and 3), control of the entire corridor from Ghazna through Bust would have been advantageous, and was probably accomplished sometime shortly after the Shansabanis' fateful victory at Ghazna in AH 569/1173 CE.[28] Ensuring this region's integration firmly within the Shansabani ambit was not only impelled by its previous Ghaznavid connections; securing the Zabulistan–Zamindawar corridor was surely necessary for the newly titled Sultan Mu'izz al-Din's further kingly aspirations and territorial ambitions.

Bust itself was a significant fortified town, following the regionally widespread layout of a royal enclave (Pers. *arg*) ensconced within a larger walled settlement (Pers. *shahristan*) (Figure 5.8). Within these type of plans, the more secure enclaves were frequently at the outer edge of the citadel,

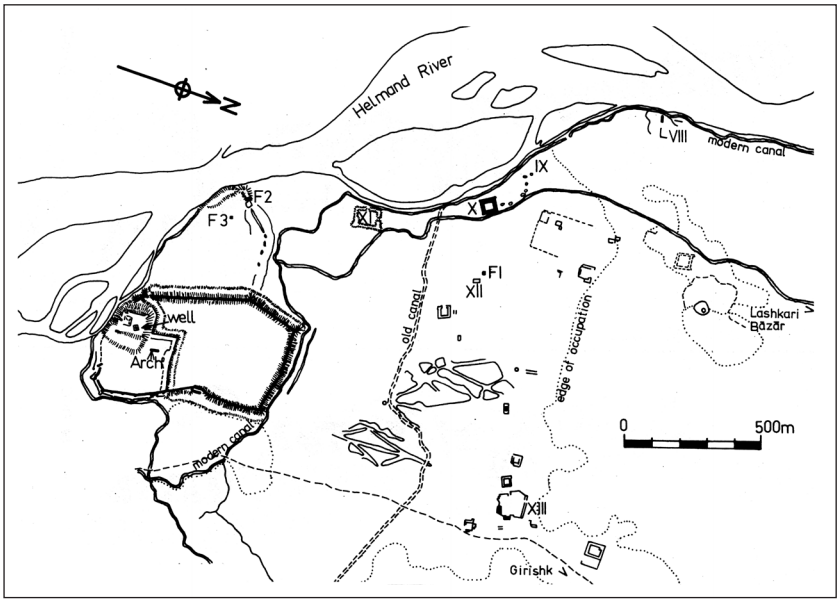


Figure 5.8 *Bust, Helmand Province, Afghanistan, general plan. From Ball 2019: No. 149.*